

fridayReview

THE HINDU

On a musical journey

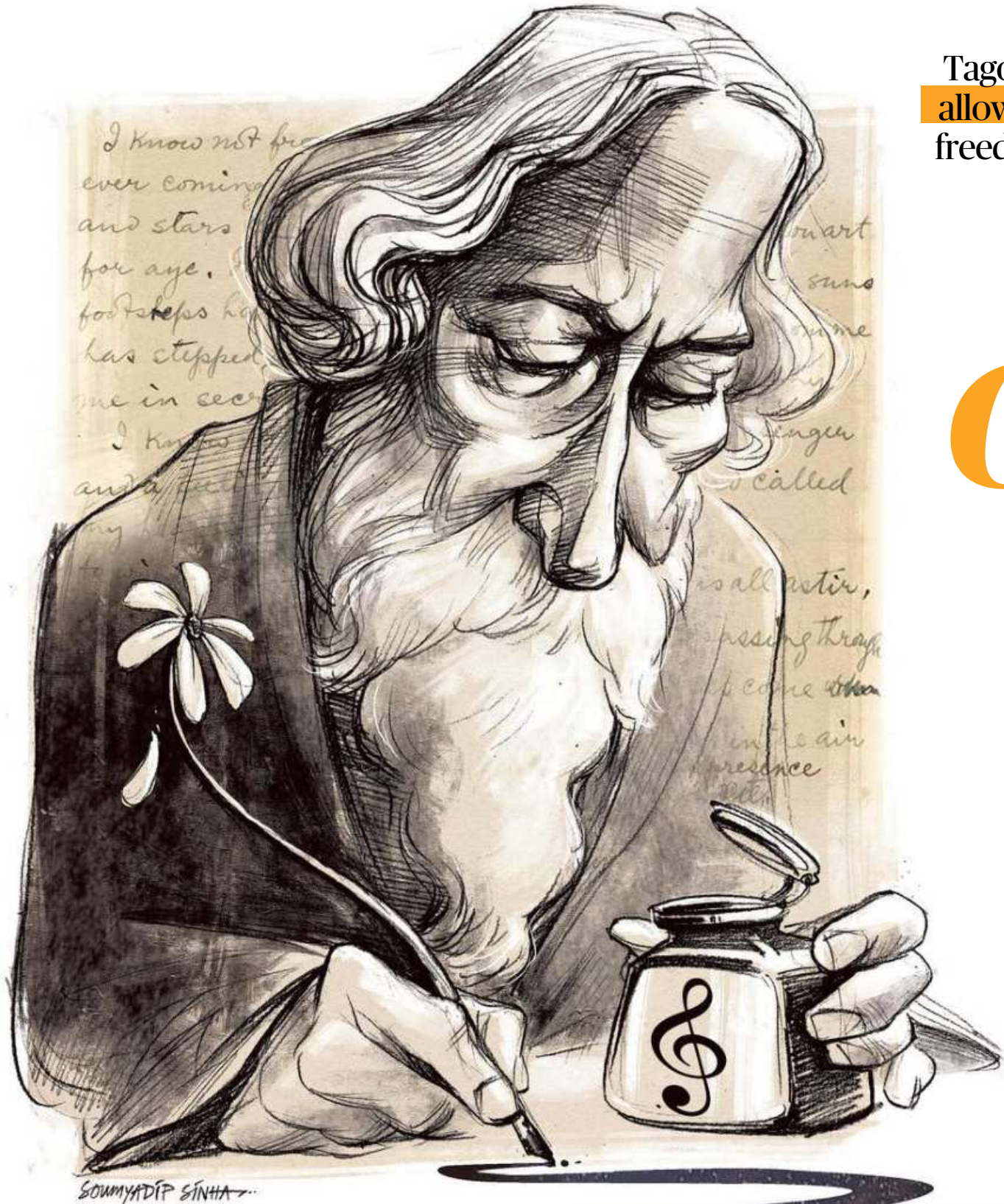
Gayathri Girish presented kritis that Dikshitar composed during his travels **p2**

Influenced by Yakshagana

Actor Abhinav Grover on how the theatrical form shaped his craft **p3**

ART FROM ACROSS THE BORDER

In Nepal's Thangka studios, spirituality finds expression in colours **p4**



Tagore's songs are dynamic texts, open to reinterpretation, allowing each generation to find new meaning in themes of freedom, love, and humanity – revisiting the poet-laureate's musical oeuvre on his 165th birth anniversary

Lyrical Chronicles

Tagore's music? Rabindra Sangeet offers the ultimate synthesis of words, tones and melody, explains Reba Som in her exemplary book, *The Singer and His Song*. Unbelievable as it may sound, Tagore has songs for every emotion. There is a song for every season; he's able to tell the story of sunshine and rain, spring blooms and winter fog. And in doing so, he unveils ideas of love, faith, devotion and surrender, introducing us to elevated thoughts, at times with disarming simplicity.

His music drew from the most rigorous of Indian classical traditions. Yet he never thought of being bound by their tenets. Adding a bend in the raga was second nature to him. He loved folk music and was inspired by the sweep of western classical music. In him was this magical amalgamation of artistry that gave birth to a unique form of music – an Indian genre in affirmation of the universality of purity.

"I know no man in my time who has done anything in the

English language to equal these lyrics," said Irish poet W.B. Yeats, while introducing some of Tagore's own translations of his songs to a gathering of English intellectuals circa 1912. Events that followed are well-known. *Gitanjali* is published in England the same year. Tagore wins the Nobel in 1913 and is knighted two years later. By then, the western world has taken note of the eponymous genre of Rabindra Sangeet and his genius of setting over 2,200 songs to his own music in the storied tradition of the 'lieder' that encompasses poetic expression in an enduring musical form to create a staggering ensemble of narratives, feelings and timeless commentary.

Debabrata 'George' Biswas, with his splendid baritone, articulates the cosmic wonder of existence in 'Aakash bhora surjo tara'. Kanika Bandopadhyay brings serenity through 'Anandadhara bohichhe bhubane', a song of universal truths, while Ritu Guha offers solace in 'Eki labonye purno pran', her tribute to the 'Lord of Life.'

Suchitra Mitra celebrates freedom that lies in the light of the skies beyond the limitations of the body and mind in 'Amar mukti aloye aloye'. Sagar Sen's intimate 'Aj jyotsnare shobai gecchhe bone' captures the quiet of a moonlit night when "all have left and I chose to stay." And Santideb Ghosh, with his 'kirtani' storytelling of *Krishnakoli*, evokes the image of the dark village girl who comes to life in the plaintive relief of a flute.

Appreciation of Tagore may be rooted in the Bengali language, but he is by no means the sole preserve of Bengal. For, his music is a well-spring of good thought, embodying all that is life. Filmmaker Ritwik Ghatak spoke of it with remarkable candour: "I cannot speak without Tagore... I have nothing new to say... in the final analysis, you will find he has the last word."

And if you are one of those still engaging with the question, 'How have we forsaken who we were to become who we are now?', you may want to turn to 'Klanti amar khoma koro prabhu' (Forgive me my weariness, oh Lord) and then perhaps, embrace continuum in the finality of, 'Achhe dukkho, achhe mrityu (there is sorrow, there is death) particularly, Srikanta Acharya's rendition, Reba Som's translation of which goes like this:

There is sorrow, there is death...
Yet laugh the sun, moon and stars
Spring arrives in the bower in varied colours
Waves merge into rising waves
Flowers scatter to blossom again
There is no erosion, there is no end
There is no trace of being impoverished,
It is at the feet of that plenitude
That my mind begs for space.

Shantanu Datta

Addressing a tutorial on the English romantics, a professor concluded: "Read Tagore, I implore you, to understand how unlike poets such as Shelley and Keats, he did not struggle to reconcile imagination and reality. This tip stayed with those students of Jadavpur University, one of whom I borrow the anecdote from to embark on this eminently rewarding but daunting endeavour to celebrate the poet-laureate's musical oeuvre on his 165th birth anniversary, which was celebrated last week.

Bengalis raised in Kolkata will readily profess how

Rabindranath Tagore has been central to their formative years. He has been omnipresent in school texts, music on the radio and records at home, not to forget the compulsive desire in each of us to sing, recite and enact his offerings with aplomb – often without concern for glaring individual limitations of craft and performance.

One of my earliest memories of Rabindra Sangeet is Hemanta Mukhopadhyay's rendition of 'Ogo nodi apon bege', a song of the river as a willing chronicler of life's many turns across meadows and landscapes. Later on, songs of 'Chandalika', the dance-drama about love pitted against social ostracism, would play on loop, gradually leading to timeless

anthems such as 'Dhono dhannay', 'More bina uthe kon shure baje' in school and college. These experiences are by no means exclusive. If anything, they are stereotypically 'Bangalee'. Yet, these have been essential, a rite of passage that paves the way towards serious cultural and intellectual exploration of Tagore songs. For the invested music lover, it is a work in progress that opens doors, at times a whole new horizon, at each hearing.

Wherein lies the essence of

Appreciation of Tagore may be rooted in the Bengali language, but he is by no means the sole preserve of Bengal. For, his music is a well-spring of good thought, embodying all that is life.

In step with Rabindra Sangeet

The National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA), Mumbai, presents 'Celebrating Tagore' on May 21 (6.30 p.m.) in its Experimental Theatre. The programme will bring alive the melody of Rabindra Sangeet through the fluid grace of Indian classical dance.

Odissi artiste, Debamitra Sengupta, a senior disciple of guru Kelucharan Mohapatra and Sutapa Talukdar, will present 'Shyama', a poignant tale of love, sacrifice and moral conflict centered

around a beautiful royal courtesan who falls in love with a noble foreign merchant, Bajrasen. When he is unjustly arrested, Shyama orchestrates his escape by persuading her devoted admirer, Uttiyo, to falsely confess to the crime – ultimately leading to his death. Though Shyama and Bajrasen flee together, the truth surfaces, leaving Bajrasen devastated by the cost of his freedom. Torn between love and guilt, he rejects Shyama, who departs



heartbroken.

Rabindranath Tagore wrote *Shyama* in 1939, a couple of years prior to his passing. Depicting the dilemmas of arrogance, selfishness, love,

remorse and jealousy as a common human weakness, Tagore emphasises the need to overcome life's impermanence and fragility through an understanding of

its true meaning

Kathak artiste Keka Sinha's performance is titled 'Robi O Raag'. She is a disciple of Bandana Sen and Reba Vidyarthi, both of

whom are direct disciples of Shambhu Maharaj of the Lucknow gharana, 'Robi O Raag' is a bouquet of three songs by Tagore, fused with Hindustani classical

compositions.

Bharatanatyam artiste Chitra Vishwanathan, with over 26 years of experience in performance and pedagogy, holds an MFA from Dr. Sandhya Purecha's Bharata College of Fine Arts, Mumbai. Her performance is based on the select works of Tagore. She will begin with 'Basonti he bhubanomohini', a vibrant ode to spring. The presentation then transitions to 'Pinakete', a powerful invocation to Shiva. Here, the mood intensifies, exploring the dynamic energy of tandava. Set within the framework of Carnatic music, this performance reflects a harmonious confluence of Tagore's literary brilliance and South Indian classical aesthetics.

Musical pilgrimage

Gayathri Girish presented Muthuswami Dikshitar not just as a composer steeped in devotion, but also as a passionate traveller



In a lec-dem at the University of Chicago, Bharat Sundar outlined simple ways to understand raga, rhythm and time

Beyond fixed notes

Krithi Raghavan

At a recent lecture-demonstration at the University of Chicago titled 'In Tune with Time', Carnatic vocalist Bharat Sundar explored the living interplay between rhythm and melody in Carnatic music, and did so with a rare blend of depth, humour, and ease.

Bharat began by discussing the pitfalls of comparing the Carnatic raga system to scales. While this reductionist framework may serve as a cognitive shortcut, it fails to capture the essence of melody in Carnatic music. A raga's identity, he said, does not come from a fixed sets of notes, but from phraseology that is vast, fluid and ever-evolving patterns of movement. In fact, he suggested the learning method should be reversed – instead of starting with fixed notes and attempting to arrive at the raga, one should first absorb the phrases that define it. The notes then become reference points, mere approximations of something far more alive. Without this awareness, we risk clinging to the simplification and lose the purpose for which it was created.

Ludwig Wittgenstein once wrote about a ladder that must be climbed and then kicked away. Every formal system, scale, grammar and map is such a ladder. Its purpose is not to be clung to, but to be used as a means to move beyond it.

Time, he suggested, is not something you just measure in music; it is something you inhabit. He spoke about how laya and tala function as frameworks through which Carnatic music organises time. Within these structures lies a world of immense creative freedom. One can work within a fixed meter while choosing how to engage with the gaps – add, subtract, extend or compress. He referenced composers such as Arunagirinathar, highlighting the playful complexity of meter, language and meaning in

works such as 'Muthai tharu'. Bharat demonstrated how misalignment among melody, rhythm and meaning can lead to unintentional comedic effects, rendering a stanza from 'Muthai tharu', which evokes vivid imagery of a war sequence, in a sweet lullaby-like tone.

He also spoke about how language should sound when sung, illustrating how Tamil intonation and its inherent sinuosity can subtly shape the rendering of another language, like Hindi, in music, and why such nuances demand careful attention.

The evening ended with a delightful Q&A session, which gave rise to more interesting ideas.

One assumption Bharat gently dismantled was that ragas carry inherent emotional associations. Emotions, he said, are subjective and shaped by one's conditioning. To illustrate this, he sang Subhapatnuvarali in multiple registers – mourning, vibrant and yearning.

The question of composing within a tradition surfaced too: how does one create within something so architecturally elaborate? His response was focused on sincerity, what we make is shaped by what we have absorbed, and if something feels true to the artiste, it can belong within the tradition even if it stretches beyond what has been familiar thus far.

The audience got to hear glimpses of Sahana, Charukesi, Thodi, Shubhapatnuvarali, Kosalam, Karaharapriya, Abheri, Atana, and even a playful Shanmukhapriya rap. At one point, he even compared the beats of the Snarky Puppy band to a Dwijavanti composition. Perhaps the most profound takeaway was his reflection on how the human need to organise information often makes us forget that art is not merely a system to be decoded, but an experience to be inhabited. By the end of the session, Carnatic music felt more accessible and intimate.



Renuka Suryanarayana

Dikshitar 250 (250th birth anniversary) may have been a focal point of the past year, but the composer's influence on Carnatic music resonates incessantly. That came through in vocalist Gayathri Girish thematic concert 'Hidden gems in Muthuswami Dikshitar's compositions', held recently at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, Mylapore. Dikshitar, the youngest of the Carnatic music Trinity, was an inveterate pilgrim,' said Gayathri at the outset.

The theme echoed the composer's passion for travel and his penchant for composing kritis

on the deities of various temples. His works are rich with references to anecdotes, rituals and festivals associated with each shrine. In that sense, Dikshitar was a historian, Gayathri observed during her well-researched presentation.

She was accompanied by M. Vijay on the violin and Poongulam S. Subramanian on the mridangam. Vijay was at his melodious best in solo raga sketches, while the mridangist seamlessly brought out the rhythmic structure of every composition.

As part of Dikshitar's kshetra kritis, Gayathri sang songs on Achaleswarar temple in Tiruvarur (Sadachaleswaram in Bhupalam), Varadaraja Perumal temple in

Kanchipuram ('Varadarajam upasmahe' in Saranga), Rathnagiriswarar temple in Nagapattinam district ('Pahimam ratnachala' in Mukhari), Bhaktavatsala Perumal temple in Thirukannamangai ('Bhaktavatsalam abhishekavalli' in Vamshavati), Subramania Swamy temple in Tiruchendur ('Sri subrahmanya mam' in Thodi) and the shrine of Kamalamba in Tiruvarur ('Sri kamalamba jayati' in Ahiri). The list also included 'Narasimha aghacha' in Mohanam and 'Tyagaraja mahadvajaroha' in Sri raga. Each kriti was preceded by a brief description of the kshetra, accompanied by a slide show of these temples. One only wished that the slides were less cluttered.

The highpoint was the song

'Bhaktavatsalam abhishekavalli', which recounts the wedding of Lakshmi and Vishnu, and how Lakshmi asked the devas to refrain from attending it. Undeterred, they are said to have swarmed the wedding in the guise of bees – a presence that, to this day, is believed to linger in Abhishekavalli Thayar's shrine. These facets were reflected in the verse 'Sura maya madhu makshika-aradhitam' (the one worshipped by honeybees, who are themselves forms of the devas).

The evening gave the audience a glimpse of the many kshetras that inspired Dikshitar's compositions, establishing him as one of the uttama vaggeyakaras.

Too many loose ends

Mayachangili, A Tamil play on corruption struggled to sustain its impact



Suganthi Krishnamachari

When corruption is endemic, an officer who plays by the rules is the odd man out. This is what happens in Brahma Fine Arts' *Mayachangili* (story, dialogue and direction by K. Prakash).

Arun (K. Prakash) is an honest police officer, whose superior Pradeep, is a man after Arun's heart. Arun pursues valuable leads which help him unravel a drug trafficking network. But when Arun is on the verge of discovering the mastermind, Pradeep vanishes. K.D. Keppamma, who takes his place, torments Arun, who begins to drink and eventually dies due to depression. His wife Usha, files a complaint against Keppamma, and the case comes to the court. The defence lawyer argues that Arun's death is due to a natural cause. But the prosecution argues that keeping a man on his toes 24/7 with frivolous demands and abusing him constitute torture, which can lead to his death.

The play had a god-man curing

Arun's son Krishna of aphasia and an inability to use his limbs, perhaps to please those who believe in miracle cures. Because the playwright had tried to pander to different segments of the audience, the play lacked the sharpness that the serious subject required. The attempt to fuse together a social theme with a sub-text on piety robbed the play of the tautness needed to move the story forward.

When a senior officer like Pradeep goes missing, wouldn't an investigation have begun at once, notwithstanding a corrupt system? Wouldn't something like this have grabbed the media's attention? This was a huge logical lapse in the script. Keppamma's vitriolic remarks against Arun were exaggerated, and Lakshmi went overboard in her portrayal of Keppamma. Dwijesh Prakash as Krishna showed a lot of promise. Usha Nandini gave a compelling performance as Arun's wife, Usha. The stage is a mirror to societal ills like corruption, and a play tackling corruption in high places is welcome, but the script needs to be improved to make the narrative more nuanced.

Love of the language

At Mudhra's Chithirai Music Festival, Sai Vignesh's concert featured rare Tamil compositions, continuing the tradition of bringing forgotten gems to the stage

G. Swaminathan

The first day of Mudhra's Chithirai Music Festival featured a concert by promising young vocalist Sai Vignesh, supported by Pappu Gyandev on the violin and Melakkaveri Balaji on the mridangam.

The festival's objective is to promote Tamil compositions. Sai Vignesh, winner of several music shows and contests, is also known for performing at live retro film music shows.

Blessed with a pleasant voice, his renditions carry verve and clarity. He opened his concert with Papanasam Sivan's 'Karunai seivai' in Hamsadhwani, dedicated to Ganesha. The swara section was brief yet engaging. He took up Poorvikalyani for alapana, focusing mostly on kaarvais rather than brigas. The raga is so versatile that it allows musicians to explore its beauty. His choice of Sudhananda Bharati's 'Kaaranam kettu vaadi' was a pleasant surprise. This kriti was popular in the days of gramophone records because of M.L. Vasanthakumari. The legendary vocalist's alapana, kriti rendition and kalpanaswaras on 'Poorana dayavulla' are unforgettable. Sai Vignesh's rendition of the kriti was enriched with well-knit swaras on the pallavi.



Rising note Sai Vignesh accompanied by Pappu Gyandev on the violin and Melakkaveri Balaji on the mridangam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The singer's brisk 'Mal maruga shanmuga', in Vasantha, served as a prelude to the elaborate raga alapana of Sankarabharanam. A weighty raga, it demands ingenuity in navigating its contours to bring forth its grandeur. The vocalist demonstrated a firm grasp of the raga's nuances. His portrayal gave him ample scope to prove his mettle. The upper octave sancharas were carefully chosen and unfolded without any overshoots or vocal aerobics.

Here too, Sai Vignesh's choice of Harikesanallur Muthiah Bhagavathar's 'Manadirkisaintha Manalan' was a novel one, as

the piece is rarely rendered on classical music platforms.. Doing full justice, he dwelt on the line 'Samarasa saravanan sarguna bodan' for niraval and followed it with interesting matrices of kalpanaswaras. The swara suite was pleasing with several permutations and combinations landing on 'shadjam'.

The richness of the kriti and Sai Vignesh's rendition stood as a testimony to his understanding of the values of Carnatic music.

Pappu Gnanadev's violin support was balanced and his responses in raga alapanas,

niravals, and swara sallies matched the singer's enthusiasm. Melakkaveri Balaji, known for bolstering the zeal of young vocalists, did the same in this concert too. His tani avaratanam was brief but impressive.

The final segment featured popular songs such as 'Eppo varuvuru' in Jhonpuri by Gopalakrishna Bharati, 'Kaana vendamo' in Sriranjani by Papanasam Sivan, and Andal's 'Tiruppavai 'Chitranchirukaale' in Madhyamavati. This Tiruppavai used to be sung in different ragas earlier. The verses fit beautifully into any raga format – a testament to its poetic brilliance.

Shilpa Anandraj
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The 7th-century Sanskrit play *Bhagavadajjukam* (bhagavat: hermit; ajjuka: courtesan) – is among the oldest surviving works in Sanskrit theatre. Celebrated as a classic instance of *prahasana* or farce, it brims with witty exchanges on dharma and the absurdity of transmigration, as the yogi and courtesan’s souls swap bodies – leaving other characters bewildered by chaos they cannot grasp.

This ancient tale finds its adaptation in English as *Yogi vs Bhogi*, directed by Mahesh Dattani and staged by Punaha Theatre. Mahesh’s retelling probes the complexities of gender – its expression, perception, spectrum and stereotypes – with humour and catharsis. The production fuses contemporary theatre’s physicality with the traditional dance-drama of Yakshagana, creating a performance where classical text and rhythm meet seamlessly.

It is within this world that actor Abhinav Grover’s journey as the yogi unfolds. Born in Haryana to Punjabi parents, raised in Rajasthan, and later drawn to Udupi in Karnataka through his studies at Manipal Institute of Technology, he discovered theatre as a calling stronger than engineering. He speaks about how destiny lured him towards Kannada and Yakshagana.

“During college years in Manipal I ventured into theatre and was hooked. After studies, I headed to the Drama School Mumbai, which was an eye-opener. I had amazing teachers who said: ‘Don’t think you have become an actor; you are now a student of acting for life and continue to learn forever.’”

“At Drama School Mumbai, I struggled to relate to Western physical theatre, unable to grasp its language. Neeraj Kabi was one of my teachers. He chose to work with a module on epic theatre where he used Bharatanatyam and Odissi to direct *Hamlet*. For the play, he collaborated with Yakshagana teacher Sanjeev Suvarna, who later became my guru. I found it tough to emote through dance or movement.”

Then a conversation with Neeraj Kabi became a turning point in Abhinav’s life. “I told him I was from Udupi when I introduced myself, but did not know Kannada or anything about Yakshagana. He



Abhinav Grover, who plays the protagonist in Mahesh Dattani’s new play, shares how the theatrical form shaped him as an actor

Rooted in culture Scenes from the play *Yogi vs Bhogi* PHOTOS COURTESY: PUNAHA THEATRE



finds its expression in *Yogi vs Bhogi*, where Abhinav plays the yogi – a role that resonates with his own transformation from a hesitant student to disciplined performer, embodying the ascetic whose soul is interchanged with the courtesan. “In *Yogi vs Bhogi*, I even speak a few dialogues in Kannada. Despite being an English play, *Yogi vs Bhogi* retains all its songs and some dialogues in Kannada. Retaining them was important to preserve the cultural resonance,” says Abhinav, who also directed his first Kannada play – Girish Karnad’s *Agni Mattu Male* – infused with Yakshagana.

Yogi vs Bhogi juxtaposes masculinity and femininity, humour and philosophical depth, speaking concurrently on metaphorical and existential levels. The production brings together talents from Mumbai – Abhijeet Singh, Aryan Tandon, Rishabh Kanti, and Anjana Aluwalia – alongside actors from Udupi and Abhinav himself. Together, they create a layered performance that blends languages and traditions without losing coherence. Yakshagana is used to portray the character of Yama, while traces of Kalari shape the character of the snake. Though staged in English, the play feels deeply rooted in local culture. Mahesh Dattani even uses silence as a powerful tool of humour.

As for Abhinav, he looks forward to exploring other varied folk forms of Karnataka and weaving them into his plays. For the moment, he making the best of both worlds – screen and theatre.

Yogi vs Bhogi will be staged on May 23 at Jagriti, Whitefield in Bengaluru.

Yakshagana as the training ground

asked me, ‘you have been there all these years, yet not experienced its arts and culture?’ That remark stuck with me. Till then, I was under the impression that I wouldn’t need to learn other art forms being a contemporary actor. That’s when I realised why I was not able to express myself through movement. I returned to Udupi and immersed myself in learning Yakshagana at Yakshagana Kendra Udupi and Yaksha Sanjeeva Yakshagana Kendra for seven years.”

Living in the gurukul came with its own set of challenges. “Mornings and evenings were spent in Yakshagana training, while days were devoted to working in a college. Learning Yakshagana was transformative, though I began late – at 21. I felt

like quitting after a month as I did not understand its rhythm or the language. The credit goes to my guru who refused to give up on me, saying ‘rhythm is in the heart – when the heart is beating, how can there be no rhythm?’ He began speaking to me in Hindi and told me that language cannot be a barrier in learning an art form.”

Soon, months turned to years, “my body started adapting, mind accepting, I adjusted to the gurukul life. At first, the early dawn-discipline felt impossible, its repetition numbing. Yet guruji’s unspoken rule revealed discipline as a holistic path – Yakshagana is total theatre – training voice, singing and acting. Meals were cooked collectively, Sundays brought visiting teachers. The



Learning Yakshagana was transformative. Yet, a month into my training, I felt like quitting because I could not grasp its rhythm or the language. The credit goes to my guru, who refused to give up on me.

ABHINAV GROVER

gurukul was an oasis where art was absorbed as much as taught and I gradually learnt to speak Kannada too,” shares Abhinav.

By 2017, he headed back to Mumbai, working there till 2020. His first big celluloid break came with *Rocket Boys*, followed by *The Railway Men* with Kay Kay Menon and R. Madhavan, where he portrays the character of Adil. Then came *Superboys of Malegaon*, *Lucca’s Two Hemispheres*, and most recently *Ikka* alongside Akshaye Khanna and Sunny Deol.

Back in Udupi during COVID, he co-founded Punaha Theatre with Venu Madhav Bhatt, staging Harold Pinter’s *The Caretaker* and now *Yogi vs Bhogi*. Over time, he not only mastered Yakshagana, but also started directing and acting in Kannada plays. This journey now

CULTUREBRIEFS

Music course

The Music Academy Madras invites applications for its special part-time classes in vocal and instrumental music. Vocal classes, for beginners, will be held twice a week as part of a four-year course. Candidates who have reached the standard of singing varnams are eligible to join directly in the third year. Instrumental classes – in mridangam, veena, and violin – will also be conducted twice a week over four years. The faculty includes Sweta Balasubramanian and N. Subasri for vocals; Padma Murali and Shobhana Swaminathan for veena; Usha Rajagopalan and Pavani Mallajosyula for violin; and S.J. Arjun Ganesh for mridangam classes. Application forms are available at the office of The Music Academy and the last date to send in applications is June 6. For details, call: 044-28112231 or 28115162.

Concert series

The Music Academy Madras will host a series of concerts, from May 18 to 21 at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall 6 p.m. The line-up: May 18: Bharatanatyam recital by Chitra Lakshumanan; May 19: Purandaradasa compositions by singer V. Subashri. She will be accompanied by Mantha Sriramya (violin) and Kaushik Sridhar (mridangam). It is organised under the endowment instituted by Sri P. Seshadri, managing trustee of Thyagaraja Music Festival Trust. May 20: A vocal concert by Pranathi Ganapuram, accompanied by P. Akshaya on the violin and M. Sarvajit Krishna on the mridangam. The event is supported by the endowment of Sri Pichumony Iyer and Smt. Kunthalam Trust in memory of Mrs. Kunthalam Pichumony Iyer. May 21: Syama Sastri Day will be celebrated, featuring Shubha Ganesan on vocals, Gayatri Vibhavari Vyakaranam on the violin, and B. Sai Shankar on the mridangam. The event is organised under the endowment of the Alibhoy Haiderbhoy Chitalwala Charitable Trust by Sri B. Natarajan.

Shailaja Tripathi

At a time when storytelling is increasingly consumed through theatre screens, television and mobile devices, the revival of large-scale mythological dance-dramas on stage feels both timely and essential. At the Kendra Dance Festival 2026, held recently in Delhi, Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra (SBKK) revived three of its landmark productions – ‘Chakravyuh’, ‘Shri Durga’, and ‘Kartikeya’ – now enriched with contemporary aesthetics and renewed relevance.

For 83-year-old Shobha Deepak Singh, who helms SBKK, “it stems from the need to bring these stories back to the stage for today’s audience. There is not only an artistic urgency, but also a deeper cultural impulse.” She inherited a love for the arts from her parents, Lala Charat Ram and Sumitra Charat Ram.

In 1952, Sumitra Charat Ram founded SBKK, which soon emerged as one of the foremost institutions championing Indian performing arts. Its dance repertoire, established in 1957, developed a distinctive vocabulary of narrative movement, reimagining mythological tales through ensemble choreography, evocative music and innovative theatrical design.

For SBKK, revisiting the old productions is also about continuity. “A repertoire survives only when it is performed, taught and passed on,” says Shobha, who believes these works offer young dancers access to a demanding and layered performance tradition, preserving not just the choreography but an entire way of working.

The productions are steeped in history. ‘Kartikeya’ started as ‘Kumar Sambhav’ in 1958,

Back to the classics

Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra revives iconic productions, reaffirming the enduring magic of live performance in a digital era



Epic renewal Scenes from the dance drama, ‘Kartikeya’ and (left) from ‘Shri Durga’. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Chakravyuh’ was first staged in 1993, and ‘Shri Durga’ in 2007. Their revival is marked by thoughtful reworking – introducing fresh choreography, lighting, costumes and sharper storytelling, all while preserving the original essence.

Each production has its own visual and movement language. While ‘Chakravyuh’ and ‘ShriDurga’ have been choreographed by Shashidharan Nair, Raj Kumar Sharma has choreographed ‘Kartikeya’.

‘Chakravyuh’, inspired by the *Mahabharata*, centres around Abhimanyu’s fateful entry into the battle formation. Rooted in the martial art-energy of Mayurbhanj Chhau, the choreography has the ensemble forming labyrinth patterns. “Abhimanyu’s tragic situation is depicted as an emotional isolation, beautifully captured through aptly choreographed movements,” says Shobha.

‘Shri Durga’ moves beyond mythology to showcase devi as a symbol of feminine strength,

resistance, dignity and selfhood. Through expansive group choreography and dramatic musical shifts, the production pursues the goddess’ transformation from a serene power to a fierce protector.

‘Kartikeya’ focuses on a relatively underexplored figure in dance. Originally it was choreographed by Pt Birju Maharaj and set to music by the Dagar Brothers.

“He is born for a divine purpose, trained as a warrior and destined to restore balance. What draws us is his journey from innocence to leadership. Blending classical forms with contemporary theatrical elements, the production weaves together episodes on Shiva, Parvati and Ganesha,” says Shobha.

The choreographies draw from Kathak, Bharatanatyam, Odissi, Kathakali, Chhau and folk traditions. According to Shobha, “It is not about breaking away from tradition, but making it alive for the present. In the digital era, these productions underline the power of live performance.”



Immersive hues
(Clockwise from left) A popular Thangka piece; an artist at work; a view of the Bhaktapur Durbar Square and a Buddha painting
PHOTOS: NEETA LAL

Neeta Lal

The first thing that struck me in Bhaktapur, Nepal, was the silence – not the absence of sound, but a kind of reverential hush that settled over its brick lanes and temple courtyards. It was the kind of quietness that prepared one for what lay behind unassuming wooden doors: worlds within worlds, painted with devotion, discipline and patience.

One of my most memorable experiences at this UNESCO World Heritage Site was being at the workshops of Thangka artists – some barely 18, others well into their 70s and 80s – who have spent their lives practising an art form that is as much a spiritual pursuit as a visual expression. Volleying between these studios, witnessing centuries-old traditions unfold was deeply immersive.

In one such workshop, tucked into a narrow alley off Durbar Square, was seated the 72-year-old master artist Tsering Lama. His fingers, stained with pigment, moved steadily across a canvas as he outlined the serene face of a Bodhisattva. “You don’t paint a thangka,” he told me without looking up. “You enter it.”

Sacred grammar

That idea – of ‘entering’ rather than creating – became the thread that tied my experience together. Thangka, rooted in Tibetan Buddhism, is not merely a decorative art. It is a disciplined spiritual practice governed by strict iconographic rules. Every line, proportion and colour have a prescribed meaning. The geometry

From pigment to prayer

A journey into Nepal’s Thangka studios, where young artists and veteran masters keep the centuries-old Buddhist art tradition alive

of a deity’s face, the angle of a hand gesture, the placement of a lotus – all these are dictated by ancient texts passed down generations.

In another workshop, 19-year-old Sonam carefully sketched a grid onto a blank canvas. “This is the foundation,” he explained. “Without the right proportions, the deity loses its spiritual integrity,” said the teen, who has been apprenticing since the age of 12, learning first to draw basic forms before graduating to more complex compositions. “It takes years before you are allowed to paint a face,” he added.

The process begins long before the first brushstroke. Cotton canvas is stretched over a wooden frame and coated with a mixture of chalk and animal glue, then polished smooth with a stone. Only then does the artist start to draw, mapping out the composition with mathematical



precision. Watching this unfold, one is struck by how little room there is for error – and how much room there is for devotion.

Time seemed to stand still inside these workshops. Hours pass as artists grind natural pigments using stone mortars – lapis lazuli for deep blues, cinnabar for vivid reds, crushed malachite for greens. Gold dust is mixed carefully and reserved for the most sacred elements. The air carried the faint metallic tang of minerals and the earthy scent of handmade materials.

“Natural colours have life,” said 45-year-old artist Pema Shrestha, holding up a small bowl of blue pigment. “Synthetic paints are easier, cheaper – but they don’t carry the same energy.” He remains committed to traditional methods despite rising costs and shrinking margins. “This is not just about

selling paintings, but about preserving a lineage,” he added.

For Buddhists in Nepal, Thangkas function as visual scriptures and meditation tools. They guide practitioners through complex cosmologies, offering a map of spiritual understanding. Deities are rendered with precise iconography – each gesture (mudra), posture and attribute are layered with meaning.



Synthetic paints may be cheaper, but they don’t carry the same energy. This is not just about selling paintings – it’s about preserving a lineage

PEMA SHRESTHA

A raised hand might signify protection; a lotus could represent purity; a flaming halo might denote transformation.

Colours, too, are deeply symbolic – Gold represents enlightenment; blue signifies infinity and wisdom; and red, power and compassion. Watching these hues come alive on canvas, one can understand how a thangka is less a painting and more a coded language – one that requires years of study to read and a lifetime to master.

It was in a sunlit studio overlooking a courtyard where 28-year-old artist Mingma, a fourth-generation Thangka painter, was at work. His grandfather, now 84, still works alongside him, occasionally correcting a line or offering guidance. Said Mingma, “We don’t learn from books alone, but by watching, doing, and being corrected.”

When asked about the challenges faced by younger artists, he paused and said, “The biggest challenge is patience. People want quick results, quick money. Thangka doesn’t give you that.” A single piece can take weeks or even months to complete, depending on its complexity.

There are economic pressures, too. While the demand for Thangkas exists – especially among tourists and collectors – mass-produced replicas have flooded the market, often at a fraction of the price. “It’s difficult to compete with machine-made or factory work,” said Mingma. “But those pieces don’t carry the same spirit.”

Despite these challenges, there’s a quiet resilience within these communities. Many have adapted by offering training programmes to international students. In one such studio, a group of students from Europe were hunched over their canvases, trying to replicate the delicate lines of a Buddha under the watchful eye of their teacher.

“This interest from foreigners gives us hope,” shared teacher Tsering Lama. “It shows that our tradition still has value.” Yet, for most artists here, the motivation transcends recognition or financial reward. An elderly artist, applying gold leaf to a halo, shared that constant learning, even after decades of practice, keeps him going. The humility and that sense of pursuit seem to define the world of Thangka painting.

As I left Bhaktapur, the images stayed with me – not just of the finished works, but the process behind them. The grinding of pigments, the steady hands, and the intergenerational conversations that unfold in quiet studios. In a rapidly changing world, where speed often trumps substance, these workshops stand as quiet acts of resistance.

A city of shadows

Spiral weaves together fictionalised narratives rooted in lived experiences across public and private spaces, examining how women confront fear and abuse in urban India

Neha Kirpal

Spiral is a monologue that examines how women navigate fear, surveillance, harassment and abuse in contemporary urban India. It brings together three fictionalised narratives drawn from lived experiences that unfold across both public and private spaces. Going by its powerful theme, *Spiral* has been structured as an intimate one-woman performance (Preeti Agrawal Mehta) piece to erase the divide between the spectator and the artiste. In the process, audiences are cast not merely as observers but as witnesses and confidants – occasionally confronting their own complicity within the worlds being revealed.

Drawing inspiration from the stark intensity of Samuel Beckett’s *Not I*, the production expects audiences to remain alert rather than slip into detached viewing. The solo performer, Preeti, inhabits multiple characters through shifts in posture, voice and movement, backed by a live musical score including the piano, strings and hand percussion that shapes the

rhythm of the narrative as much as the spoken word. “Preeti, whose perspective as a mother to a 24-year-old brought an entirely fresh emotional understanding to the work. Working with her pushed us to rebuild parts of the play and rediscover the material in new ways,” Says Mohit.

Designed for intimate venues and smaller audiences, the idea for play came from years of observation. “While studying at Delhi University and working in theatre, I was constantly around conversations, rehearsals, gatherings and friendships where I noticed that women often moved through the same spaces very differently from men. There was always an invisible burden they carried simply because they were women. What stayed with me even more was how little resolution or justice seemed to come out of many of these experiences,” said Mohit Mukherjee, the director of *Spiral*. Wanting to respond to these realities through theatre, Mohit was aware of the limitations of telling such stories as a man. “I did not want to pretend to possess an experience that was not mine,” he added. That is why bringing a



woman co-writer, Ananya Jain, into the process became important.

The first act follows what begins as a simple run through the city but slowly turns into something deeply unsettling. “The character feels watched, followed and constantly unsafe. Whether the threat is real or partly imagined is never fully clarified. What matters is that the fear itself is real. It is exhausting, consuming and yet strangely normalised within the experience of moving through a city as a woman.”



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MOHIT MUKHERJEE



Breaking silence Preeti Agrawal Mehta in *Spiral*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The second act shifts into the private space of the home, where the violence is quieter and more difficult to name. According to Mohit, “It exists in pauses, silences and things left unsaid. The audience is placed in an uncomfortable position where they become witnesses to the emotional and physical abuse unfolding before them, while also feeling implicated by their inability or unwillingness to intervene.”

The final act examines the aftermath of abuse through the flood of advice, judgement and moral policing that often surrounds survivors. “The audiences slowly piece together what may have happened, but the larger focus remains on the social conditioning that teaches people to shame, doubt and correct rather than listen,” said Mohit. None of the stories rely on sensational dialogues or extraordinary situations. Much of what is said echoes phrases we hear in everyday life. “That familiarity is what makes the world of *Spiral* unsettling.”

The seed for *Spiral* was sown sometime after 2020 when Mohit came across a news report about a sexual assault in a village in

Haryana. “What shook me was not only the violence itself but the response from two elderly women in the village who blamed the survivor and spoke about her clothes as if they had invited the crime. That moment stayed with me for a long time.” From there, began the

research, listening and collecting fragments of stories, conversations and experiences.

Music has always been central to Mohit’s work. Growing up, he was deeply influenced by the scores of films such as *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial*, *Harry Potter*, *Inception*, *Black Panther* and *Oppenheimer*, and by composers such as John Williams, Hans Zimmer and Ludwig Göransson. “Whenever I imagine a narrative, music is usually the first thing I hear. I begin by thinking about the emotional rhythm of the piece. Then come the questions of instrumentation, live or recorded sound and whether the world needs a vocalist.”

For *Spiral*, the music never allows the audience to fully relax. Deepak on the drums and cajón, alongside Ashim on the handpan, create an atmosphere of constant tension and unease. Yusra’s Hindustani vocals bring a haunting sense of pathos to the play, while Anil Chawla on the keys moves seamlessly across pop, rock, jazz and Hindustani folk to complete the ensemble. Further, one of India’s leading puppeteers, Shameem’s contribution to the scenography, puppet design and shadow work adds depth and texture to the production.

Each performance is followed by interactive discussions that encourage audiences to reflect on issues of gender, safety, voyeurism, complicity and social conditioning. “These post-show discussions come from a simple belief that there is little value in telling stories if they remain confined to theatre spaces alone,” he said.

The project’s long-term vision is to continuously adapt and expand, incorporating stories, responses and experiences gathered through participatory workshops. “Because the questions *Spiral* engages with cannot remain static,” said Mohit.